God, whereas a fervent communist isn't religious, because communism has no gods. However, religion is created by humans rather than by gods, and it is defined by its social function rather than by the existence of deities. Religion is *anything* that confers superhuman legitimacy on human social structures. It legitimises human norms and values by arguing that they reflect superhuman laws.

Religion asserts that we humans are subject to a system of moral laws that we did not invent and that we cannot change. A devout Jew would say that this is the system of moral laws created by God and revealed in the Bible. A Hindu would say that Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva created the laws, which were revealed to us humans in the Vedas. Other religions, from Buddhism and Daoism to Nazism, communism and liberalism, argue that the superhuman laws are natural laws, and not the creation of this or that god. Of course, each believes in a different set of natural laws discovered and revealed by different seers and prophets, from Buddha and Laozi to Hitler and Lenin.

A Jewish boy comes to his father and asks, 'Dad, why shouldn't we eat pork?' The father strokes his long white beard thoughtfully and answers, 'Well, Yankele, that's how the world works. You are still young and you don't understand, but if we eat pork, God will punish us and we will come to a bad end. It isn't my idea. It's not even the rabbi's idea. If the rabbi had created the world, maybe he would have created a world in which pork was perfectly kosher. But the rabbi didn't create the world – God did it. And God said, I don't know why, that we shouldn't eat pork. So we shouldn't. Capeesh?'

In 1943 a German boy comes to his father, a senior SS officer, and asks, 'Dad, why are we killing the Jews?' The father puts on his shiny leather boots, and meanwhile explains, 'Well, Fritz, that's how the world works. You are still young and you don't understand, but if we allow the Jews to live, they will cause the degeneration and extinction of humankind. It's not my idea, and it's not even the Führer's idea. If Hitler had created the world, maybe he would have created a world in which the laws of natural selection did not apply, and Jews and Aryans could all live together in perfect harmony. But Hitler didn't create the world. He